It was not the done thing to take on the man on the boundary. It was deemed too risky to attempt to hit the ball over the head of the fielder at deep mid-on. Far better to advance down the wicket to fashion a chip shot, like a golfer, over extra cover and into the gap for a couple. It was essentially cautious batting for relatively limited reward. Coaches were insurance salesmen. Now they're circus ringmasters. If you're caught in the deep, you're expected to shrug your shoulders, admit you mishit it and try again next time. Nowadays the big shot is perfected in the nets, like a booming drive on a golf range. The odds are overwhelmingly in its favour.

As emerging players at Essex, we would never have thought of standing in the middle of the square at Chelmsford and bombing the ball into the river. If you hit a boundary, you followed Goochy's edict, took a single next ball and got off strike. Perceptions have changed. In Jos's eyes a sequence of 6, 4, 6, 1 is better cricket. The white-ball cricket is about transference of power and freedom of spirit.

Modern bats are bigger in profile, with an inviting sweet spot, but less heavy because the wood is drier. They tend not to last as long, and break more easily, so equipment isn't a major factor in the revolution. I used my best bat, a lovely thin yellow-handled thing, in 2005. It was so responsive I lent it to Ravi Bopara. Legend has it that Albert Trott, who played Test cricket for both Australia and England, hit a ball over the Lord's pavilion in 1899, so that can't have been a bad bit of timber.

A glance in the gym would offer a better indication of change. It used to be a no-go area for batsmen. Now every player has a tailored strength-and-conditioning programme. I'm no bio-mechanist, but it stands to reason that if you have a lot of muscle behind a well-timed shot, the ball will disappear into the distance.

Mentally, though, it is a different proposition. I shared a net with Alex Hales in my last one-day series. He had the ability to run down the wicket and hit the net-spinners for six at will, off every delivery. His Gimp was obviously telling him, 'Don't worry, you can do it,' but he didn't quite get it right at game time and was caught at deep mid-off a couple of times.

I said to him, 'It must be really hard being you.' By that I meant it was understandable that he should listen to the inner voice telling him he could clear the rope by seventy yards. That sort of self-knowledge can be dangerous since it leads to a subconscious assumption it is possible to hit